

Population

For thousands of years before the invention of farming, the total human population was probably 15 million at most. Once people began to grow food about 9,000 years ago, the population began to increase, and by 1800 CE there were almost a billion people on Earth. With better technology and health care, the population has reached a staggering seven billion today.

LIVING OFF THE LAND

Until about 9,000 years ago, everyone lived by hunting animals and gathering wild food. Some tribal peoples around the world still do. Wild food is often seasonal and limited, which restricts how many people can live on the same area of land. This is one reason why the prehistoric population remained so small.

► HUNTER-GATHERERS

The San or bushmen in Namibia, southwest Africa, search for wild game, roots, and berries using methods unchanged for thousands of years.



FARMING REVOLUTION

Populations began to rise when people figured out how to produce more food by domesticating animals and planting crops. They also learned how to dry and store crops that could be eaten in seasons when other foods were scarce. Storing extra food also meant that not everyone had to work on the land all year round—some people could do other work. By 3000 BCE, farmers such as these in Egypt were supporting a large and complex society.